

# Tips for Preventing Online Rental Scams

Consumers are at risk from online rental scams. Scammers have different methods for pulling information from online listings to make fraudulent listings of their own. They especially like to advertise on websites like Craigslist, Facebook Marketplace, and others. It's important to learn how to spot a scam, and how to protect your listings from them.

## Types of Scams

- Online rental scam: Con artists use real estate listing information to fraudulently rent out a property. Even if the property is listed for sale, scammers will create a fake rental ad, collect upfront security deposits from unsuspecting prospective tenants, and take the money and run.
- Scraping (web scraping): This is a software technique that harvests listing photos, addresses, and descriptions. Scraping can be used to create very realistic-looking fake rental ads.

## Tips to Avoid Scams

To avoid scams-or at least catch them right away-you can set up online alerts to monitor your listings and search for images of your listings being used on rental sites.

- Google alert: This allows you to set up an alert to monitor your online listings.
- "If this, then that" alert: This allows you to create a "recipe" to monitor your online listings. Google alerts do not always show Craigslist results, so that's where "if this, then that" comes in.
- Google image search: This allows you to use an actual listing photo to search for other Internet sites where it appears.

## What To Do If You've Been Scammed

If you suspect that your real estate listing has been scammed, you can usually report the scam to the website on which it appears to have it removed. You may need to submit proof that it's your listing (such as a link to your brokerage's website, which shows the *actual* listing. You can also file a complaint with the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) or the Federal Trade Commission (FTC).